

Comparing Tech Hubs Beyond Salary

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My collection map: https://johnhazukajr.github.io/techmarket_curation/#/map

Why I made this guide

I am getting closer to graduating, and I have been trying to figure out what makes a tech market worth considering after school. Salary is an obvious place to start, but a salary by itself does not tell me much. Rent, home prices, transportation, childcare, and the kind of jobs available all change what that number means. I made this guide for college students and recent graduates who are comparing places to start a tech career and want a clearer way to look at the full picture.

My collection has 25 annotated sources covering 20 metro areas. It includes government data, regional reports, housing tools, resident reviews, and online discussions. The sources do not all answer the same question, which is part of the point. I use the national data to compare places on a common basis, then use local sources to understand details the national numbers miss. The collection map lets readers explore the metros and source notes themselves.

A job market number is not a job offer

I would start with the kind of work I want to do and look for actual openings in that field. The Bureau of Labor Statistics gives employment and wage estimates by occupation and metro, so it is useful for comparing places using the same source. The map uses its May 2025 annual mean for computer and mathematical occupations. That includes people at different career stages, though, so I would not use it as my expected starting salary. It also does not say which employers are hiring right now. ^[1]

For a new graduate, I would put that broad BLS number next to entry-level salary information, current job postings, and the details of a real offer. Levels.fyi is closer to the entry-level question, but its reported compensation can include stock and bonuses as well as base salary. I would compare base pay first, since it is the part of compensation that is easiest to plan around month to month. Submitted salaries can be useful for spotting a range, but they do not guarantee what a local employer will pay. ^[2]

Orlando shows why it helps to separate workforce size from starting pay. The Orlando Economic Partnership reports 77,700 tech workers in 2024 and says the area was projected to approach 80,000 in 2025. Its definition combines tech occupations and jobs at tech companies while avoiding overlap, so it is not a count of open positions. The same article reports a 2024 median salary of \$103,000 for workers in tech occupations, not entry-level workers. Those details make the article useful background on Orlando's tech economy, but they do not replace checking current openings and entry-level offers. ^[3]

CBRE and the Tampa Bay Partnership give broader regional context. CBRE compares tech talent markets and workforce trends, while the Tampa Bay report looks across several indicators such as wages, housing, transportation, and talent. These reports can help me decide which places deserve a closer look. Their regions and measures are not always the same as the metro definitions in BLS or Census data, so I would check the geography and date before comparing a headline number with another source. ^{[13] [14]}

Put pay next to housing

The Tampa and Orlando figures on my map make the salary and housing connection easier to see. For May 2025, BLS lists an annual mean of \$108,860 for computer and mathematical occupations in Tampa and \$105,980 in Orlando. The 2024 Census median gross rent is \$1,776 per month in Tampa and \$1,877 in Orlando. Median home values are \$387,000 and \$409,000, respectively. These figures point to a difference worth investigating: Tampa's occupational mean is higher while its metro medians for rent and home value are lower. But the wage is an average across experience levels, the housing figures are medians for different households, and the years do not line up exactly. This is a first comparison, not proof that one person would be better off in Tampa. ^[1] ^[4]

The Census American Community Survey is a useful baseline because I can compare the same housing measures across metros. Still, a metro median does not tell me what a current listing costs, how many bedrooms it has, or whether it is near a job. Zillow and Redfin can help me follow current housing trends, but each uses its own measures and update schedule. Before I compare numbers, I would match the housing type, geography, and date as closely as I can. Then I would look at real listings in areas I might actually live. ^[4]

^[6] ^[7]

Sarasota is a good reminder that a place can be appealing for reasons beyond its tech job count, while still requiring a closer look at housing. HUD's North Port-Sarasota-Bradenton analysis covers employment, population, sales, rentals, construction, and expected demand. It gives more context than one home-price number, but it describes conditions in April 2025 and includes projections. It does not settle whether a particular neighborhood fits someone's commute, housing budget, or job search. ^[5]

The rest of the budget changes the comparison

Housing is only one part of what a paycheck has to cover. The Bureau of Economic Analysis Regional Price Parities give a broad comparison of price levels, with 100 representing the national average. On the map, Tampa's 2023 overall parity is 103.4 and Orlando's is 101.1. Their housing price levels are 123.3 and 121.0. These indexes suggest that housing costs in both metros were above the national level in that data year, even though the overall price comparisons differ. They are not rent quotes or household budgets, and they do not tell me exactly what groceries, insurance, or transportation will cost. ^[8]

The map also shows how different the comparison can look in another region. Pittsburgh's 2023 overall parity is 94.4 and housing price level is 73.5, while Raleigh's is 98.0 and 104.0. That makes Pittsburgh a useful place to examine if housing cost is a major factor, and Raleigh a useful comparison for someone looking at a different tech market. These indexes alone cannot establish which is the better move. I would still need to match likely pay, actual housing options, and the costs that matter to me. ^[8]

MIT's Living Wage Calculator adds a household view by estimating basic costs for different household types and locations. The Department of Labor's National Database of Childcare Prices can help with the childcare part of the budget. Its latest county-level file covers 2008 through 2022, so it is useful for comparing patterns but not a current quote. I would use these tools alongside the BEA index: BEA helps compare general price levels, while the calculators get closer to specific expenses. Both are starting estimates. A real budget still needs actual housing, transportation, health insurance, debt payments, savings, and whatever work or family arrangements apply. ^[9] ^[21]

Housing trends also need context. The State of the Nation's Housing report and Brookings' discussion of housing costs help explain wider pressures that can affect several markets at once. They are useful for understanding why affordability changes, but they do not tell me what a particular household will pay next month. I would use those sources to ask better questions, then return to local listings and current costs. ^[22] ^[23]

Safety and daily life need more than one source

I would be careful about treating any citywide crime figure as a complete answer about safety. The FBI's 2024 data is an official starting point, but it reports crime known to law enforcement and the available metro table does not include every place in my collection. The map leaves the violent-crime metric blank for Atlanta, Miami, Orlando, Tampa, and North Port–Sarasota–Bradenton because the source does not publish an MSA row for them there. A blank is more honest than filling in a number from a different geography and acting like the comparison is even. For a place I am seriously considering, I would look for local data and learn about specific neighborhoods. ^[10] ^[24]

Resident surveys and reviews help with another part of the question: how people describe everyday life and city services. Austin's 2025 community survey and Raleigh's 2024 survey ask residents about quality of life and local priorities. They can bring up concerns such as growth, housing, transportation, or services, but they cover city limits and different years. They do not represent every suburb in the metro. ^[11] ^[12]

Niche reviews and Reddit discussions can also point me toward details to research. People may mention traffic, weather, housing, access to outdoor activities, or the feel of a neighborhood. Those experiences matter, but the commenters are not a representative sample. A thread comparing six cities is especially useful for seeing what one person values, not for deciding what most recent graduates want. I use personal accounts to create questions, then check those questions against data or local information. ^[15] ^[16] ^[17] ^[18] ^[19] ^[20]

I also need to look at schools, childcare, parks, and commuting separately if they matter to my situation. My collection now includes tools for school information and childcare costs, but those tools do not create a consistent quality score for every metro. A citywide number cannot tell me whether a specific school or commute fits. I would use the National Database of Childcare Prices and the Department of Education's Elementary and Secondary Information System to narrow down areas, and then confirm details locally. ^[9] ^[21] ^[25]

How I would use the map

The map is meant to help me narrow down places, not pick a winner for everyone. I would first filter for metros with opportunities in the kind of tech role I want. Then I would compare likely entry-level base pay with housing I could actually see myself renting or buying. After that, I would estimate a full monthly budget and check commuting, safety, childcare, schools, parks, and resident comments for the neighborhoods I am considering.

I would keep notes on the year, geography, and type of each number. For example, a BLS metro wage, a Census metro housing median, a BEA price index, and a city resident survey answer different questions. Putting them in one chart does not make them interchangeable. The map labels those differences and links back to the original sources, so someone can decide whether a number fits the question they have.

My main takeaway so far is that a strong-looking tech market is only one part of a move. Tampa and Orlando show how wages, rents, and home values can point in different directions even within the same state. Pittsburgh and Raleigh show why broad price indexes can help identify a comparison worth researching, but

cannot substitute for current job offers or household budgets. I would rather narrow the list using several kinds of evidence than rank cities with one score. The right place will depend on the job, the housing, and the everyday tradeoffs each person is willing to make.

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